WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

FERTILISERS

↘ PRODUCE MORE AT HOME: Expand and modernise urea manufacturing capacity, reduce dependence on imported natural gas through coal gasification-based urea production

↘ SECURE SUPPLIES ABROAD: Diversify fertiliser sourcing to reduce overdependence on the Gulf and China

↘ REDUCE WASTEFUL USE: Promote balanced nutrient application to curb excessive urea use, gradually shift towards a targeted DBT regime in place of price-linked subsidies

PULSES

↘ FIX THE YIELD GAP: Raise yields from 925 kg/ha to 1,150 kg/ha via better seeds, climate-resilient varieties, pest management and district-level action plans targeting low-productivity pulse belts

↘ MAKE MSP MATTER: Cultivating pulses must be made as rewarding as rice and wheat by ensuring credible MSP support and assured procurement of tur, urad and masoor

↘ INTERCROP AT SCALE: Expand pulse acreage by intercropping in sugarcane and cotton fields and region-specific crop planning, not compete with foodgrains

EDIBLE OILS

↘ DELIVER THE MISSION: Achieve the National Mission on Edible Oils' target of raising cooking oil production to 25.45 MT by 2030-31, enough to meet about 72 per cent of projected demand

↘ EXERCISE CAUTION: Expand palm oil cultivation in high-rainfall regions, while balancing its high water needs, environmental risks and long gestation period

↘ REWARD THE FARMER: Raise oilseed yields through better technology, seeds and market linkages, while providing farmers a stable policy environment despite the need to balance producer and consumer interests

WHAT THE DOMESTIC OILSEED FARMER IN INDIA NEEDS IS THE ASSURANCE THAT MADE US SELF-SUFFICIENT IN WHEAT AND RICE—CREDIBLE, PREDICTABLE PURCHASE AT THE FARM GATE

retail price surge. By May 2025, the government reversed course, halving customs duty to cool shelf prices. This tactical approach seems unavoidable, but it signals income unreliability to farmers. Meanwhile, the demand gets fatter: edible oil consumption grew by 83.68 per cent in rural areas and 48.74 per cent in urban areas between 2004-05 and 2022-23. The PM's appeal notwithstanding, oil won't stop smoking on Indian kadhais, burning a hole of $20 billion (Rs 1.9 lakh crore) in its forex reserves.

To be fair, India did not ignore its edible oil crisis, it tackled it with missions, seed programmes, price support, tariff changes and viability-gap payments for farmers. What it never confronted was the central contradiction: cheap imports were serving as a silent inflation cushion, while domestic oilseed farmers never got the assurance that made wheat and rice self-sufficient: credible, predictable purchase at the farm gate.

The lesson travels beyond edible oils. The crops India still imports heavily, or fails to price fairly at home, are precisely those the 'procurement state' was not built for: oilseeds, pulses and the fruits and vegetables that perish for want of cold chains and processing. They need the same public investment that cereals received decades ago: procurement confidence, storage, grading, primary processing near farms and market access that lets growers retain more value instead of surrendering it to intermediaries.

The wheat-and-rice system delivered grain security because the state built the plumbing for it. For most other crops, policy has relied on the market, and the market has repeatedly chosen the cheaper import. Millions of household cutbacks cannot achieve what four decades of policy have not. The Hormuz strait may reopen, tankers may sail and panic may subside. But until India takes the hard choice of fixing its farm policies, it will keep wiring nearly $35 billion (Rs 3.3 lakh crore) a year overseas for the food and farm inputs it failed to build at home. ■